

How You Got Happiness?

J. Krishnamurti

A nonlinear book on happiness, fear, attention, relationship, meditation, and freedom from
J. Krishnamurti's official talks and dialogues
Lecture notes organized by [LazyingArt LLC](#) with [Video2Book](#)

Original talks and dialogues by J. Krishnamurti. Source material preserved by the Krishnamurti Foundation Trust. Notes organized by [LazyingArt LLC](#) with [Video2Book](#).

Contents

I	The False Map Of Happiness	1
1	Pleasure As Repetition	2
1.1	Pleasure Is Not Defined By Its Object	2
1.2	The Tree And The Demand For More	3
1.3	Question & Answer	3
1.4	Attention Instead Of Control	4
1.4.1	Question & Answer	4
1.5	The Refusal Of Inner Possession	5
1.6	Discipline Means Learning	5
1.7	A Map For The Book	6

Part I

The False Map Of Happiness

Chapter 1

Pleasure As Repetition

The first false map of happiness is not crude indulgence. It is more precise than that. In the San Diego dialogue between J. Krishnamurti and Dr. Alan W. Anderson, the inquiry enters through a familiar uncertainty: pleasure, enjoyment, delight, joy, and happiness seem to belong together. Ordinary language lets them lean toward one another. A person may speak of being pleased, of enjoying, of joy, as though these were degrees of one movement.

Krishnamurti asks that the assumption be slowed down. The question is not whether the words are related. The question is whether pleasure has any actual continuity with joy or happiness. We can write the opening uncertainty as a deliberately unresolved relation:

$$\text{pleasure} \quad ? \quad \text{enjoyment} \quad ? \quad \text{joy} \quad ? \quad \text{happiness}. \quad (1.1)$$

The question marks are essential. This book begins by refusing to let vocabulary answer an inward question.

1.1 Pleasure Is Not Defined By Its Object

Krishnamurti's first move is to remove the comfort of noble examples. Pleasure may appear in eating, walking, money, sex, possession, knowledge, the idea of God, the wish to hurt, the wish to dominate, or the brutality of political power. The object changes. The movement remains recognizable.

The working distinction is:

$$\text{pleasure} = \text{the movement of thought in a direction}. \quad (1.2)$$

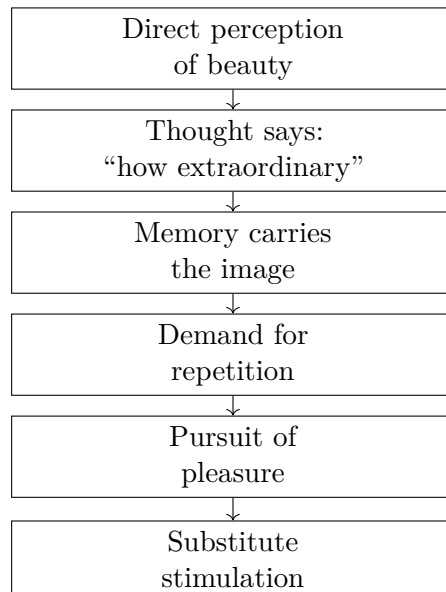
This is not a psychological law. It is a compact way of preserving the dialogue's order. Pleasure is sustained, nourished, and kept going. It moves toward having, repeating, continuing, or defending.

The same structure appears in possession:

$$\text{object seen or held} \longrightarrow \text{wanting it}, \quad (1.3)$$

$$\text{wanting it} \longrightarrow \text{possession}, \quad (1.4)$$

$$\text{possession} \longrightarrow \text{pleasure sustained}. \quad (1.5)$$



Transcript-based reconstruction of the pleasure sequence in the tree example.

When this movement is obstructed, Krishnamurti names its consequence:

$$\text{thwarted pleasure} \longrightarrow \text{frustration} \longrightarrow \text{anger, jealousy, violence.} \quad (1.6)$$

Pleasure, in this sense, is not made harmless by being called spiritual, cultural, romantic, or respectable. Its structure has to be read.

1.2 The Tree And The Demand For More

The central example is quiet: a single tree on a hill, green meadow, water, deer, flowers, shadow. There is direct perception. One sees. In that first seeing there is no possession, no inward collector, no thought saying that this must be stored.

Then one turns away. Thought enters and says that it was extraordinary. It asks to have it again. The first perception is now carried forward as memory, image, demand, and pursuit:

$$\text{perception} \longrightarrow \text{thought} \longrightarrow \text{memory} \longrightarrow \text{repetition} \longrightarrow \text{pursuit.} \quad (1.7)$$

This is the spine of the inquiry. The pleasure is not in the original seeing of the tree. Pleasure begins when thought takes what was seen and asks for continuity.

Anderson's examples of encore and festival widen the case. Repetition is not only private. A culture can organize itself around the attempt to repeat intensity: the encore, the festival, the cycle of living it up and living it down. Krishnamurti accepts this as the same movement. Thought nourishes pleasure and gives it direction.

1.3 Question & Answer

Question. When does enjoyment become pleasure?

Term	Working distinction
Pleasure	Thought-sustained movement in a direction; linked to memory, repetition, and pursuit.
Enjoyment	Immediate enjoyment; becomes pleasure when thought demands more.
Delight	Direct freshness, not yet organized as pursuit.
Joy	Not invited, not repeated by will, not a continuity of pleasure.
Happiness	Not known as an object while present; named only afterward.

Transcript-based distinction among the opening terms.

Answer. Enjoyment becomes pleasure when thought says, “I have enjoyed it; I must have more of it.” The change is not in the original enjoying. It is in the entry of thought, memory, image, demand, and direction.

Question. Does pleasure therefore become joy or happiness if refined?

Answer. In this dialogue, no continuity is granted. Pleasure belongs to thought moving in a direction. Joy and happiness are not invited, repeated, accumulated, or possessed. One may name happiness afterward, but in the moment itself it is not held as an object.

1.4 Attention Instead Of Control

The inquiry then raises its practical obstacle. If thought turns enjoyment into the pursuit of pleasure, should thought be controlled? Krishnamurti presents the traditional religious answer in order to reject it. Control means suppression, conflict, and fragmentation. It is still thought acting upon thought:

$$\text{thought interferes} \longrightarrow \text{control thought} \longrightarrow \text{suppression, conflict, fragmentation.} \quad (1.8)$$

The alternative is not carelessness. It is complete attention. Anderson clarifies that this does not mean muscular effort or forced concentration. Krishnamurti’s phrase is simpler: be wholly there. In such attention, thought does not enter as the demand for repetition:

$$\text{complete attention} \longrightarrow \text{no demand for repetition} \longrightarrow \text{action without control.} \quad (1.9)$$

1.4.1 Question & Answer

Question. If thought interferes with enjoyment, must thought be controlled?

Answer. No. Control belongs to the same divided movement. Krishnamurti’s answer is attention, not as a method, practice, or cultivated skill, but as whole seeing.

The poisonous bottle example gives the point its sharpest form. If one really sees that the bottle is poisonous, there is no need to control oneself into not drinking. Clear perception is already action. Control becomes necessary only when the label has not been read clearly.

$$\text{watching} \equiv \text{discipline} \equiv \text{action}. \quad (1.10)$$

The equivalence sign is only a notation for the spoken compression. It means that actual watching is not a preliminary to discipline or action. In the seeing itself there is order.

1.5 The Refusal Of Inner Possession

Anderson then tries to name a support behind this intelligence, some abiding source that sustains the person. Krishnamurti refuses the formulation. It opens the door to God, higher self, Atman, or a permanent inward entity. The refusal matters because it prevents attention from becoming doctrine.

The safer relation is:

$$\text{observation} + \text{attention} + \text{careful seeing} \longrightarrow \text{intelligence}. \quad (1.11)$$

Even this arrow must be read cautiously. Observation is not a technique for manufacturing intelligence. In actual seeing, intelligence is present.

This refusal continues in the story of the monk by the sea. The monk says he has arrived because he has controlled his senses, body, thoughts, and desires. Krishnamurti asks whether one can hold the sea in one's hand. When the water is held, it is no longer the sea. The same is true of the breeze and the earth. What is held may be only words. The story exposes a subtler pleasure: the pleasure of spiritual achievement, possession, and arrival.

1.6 Discipline Means Learning

Once control and possession are set aside, discipline must be redefined. In the ordinary religious sense, discipline often means conformity, suppression, practice, or adjustment to a pattern. Krishnamurti returns the word to learning:

$$\text{discipline} = \text{learning}. \quad (1.12)$$

Learning here is not accumulation. It is the active capacity to hear, see, and observe. A cultivated capacity may take time, but perception in this inquiry does not:

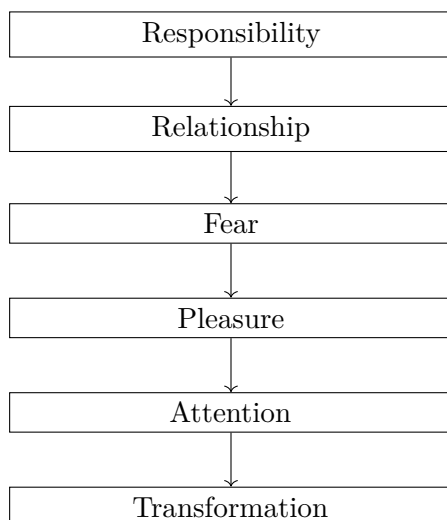
$$\text{cultivated capacity} \sim \text{time}, \quad (1.13)$$

$$\text{perception} \not\sim \text{time}. \quad (1.14)$$

Anderson notices the reversal. We commonly imagine perception perfected at the end of practice. Krishnamurti reverses the order: freedom is not at the end, but at the beginning. Observation, learning, and action occur together:

$$\text{seeing} + \text{learning} + \text{acting} \text{ occur together}. \quad (1.15)$$

This is why learning about pleasure brings its own order. It is not imposed order. It is the order that appears when the movement has been read.



Transcript-based reconstruction of Krishnamurti's closing map of the inquiry.

1.7 A Map For The Book

Near the end of the dialogue, Krishnamurti gathers the wider inquiry as a map: responsibility, relationship, fear, pleasure, attention, transformation. This first chapter therefore does more than answer whether pleasure brings happiness. It establishes the method of the whole book: read the movement exactly, without authority, without interpretation, without turning insight into possession.

The answer to the title question is therefore not a moral condemnation of pleasure. Pleasure is understood as repetition, continuity, and pursuit. Enjoyment can end as it happens. Happiness and joy are lost when thought tries to continue them. Attention reads the movement as it occurs, and in that reading the false map begins to lose its authority.